China remained a threat, and India still hoped that, when the need arose, the US would directly or indirectly help. Delhi continued to worry about Chinese intrusions, its killing of a patrol party, and troop concentration along the border through fall 1965.[33] India's internal situation also reinforced the need for the US. The 1965 drought had made assistance critical. Moreover, the war had weakened the Indian economy even though it had strengthened Prime Minister Shastri politically.[34] Subsequently, the premier's sudden death just after he signed the Tashkent agreement in January 1966 heightened the political imperative for getting aid, with the acting prime minister Gulzarilal Nanda expressing concern to Rusk about the viability of democracy in the absence of socioeconomic development.[35]

The need to maintain the American option led to Indian policymakers' efforts to reassure the US. Before accepting the Soviet offer of postwar mediation, Indian officials had solicited the US reaction, explaining that they wanted to accept in order to get Moscow on India's side if China attacked again.[36] They also moved to temper the anti-American rhetoric that had followed the war. Policymakers realized that public criticism of the US did not just upset American officials—it could also tie their own hands at a time when they knew that the US continued to be essential to their objectives. Washington noticed the criticism related to the war and food aid, but also that the US was "being let off much lighter" than the UK. Furthermore, a statement from the Indian government clarified that the US was not using food assistance to apply "political pressure."[37] There was, Bowles reported, an overall "desire to bring the situation back into balance."[38]

Indian policymakers were concerned that their harsh words—for domestic purposes—had done damage. An anxious Shastri asked Bowles if there was a change in America's India policy.[39] Indian officials indicated that the prime minister was keen to visit the US to clear the air.[40] Shastri's senior aide Lakshmi Kant (L. K.) Jha noted the Indian government's concern about the state of the relationship. He reminded Bowles about the countries' mutual dependence, noting, "India badly need[s] the US and if there is to be an independent non-Communist Asia with an effective block on Chinese expansionism, the US also need[s] India."[41]